

The National Institute of Mental Health: <https://www.nimh.nih.gov/health/publications/what-is-telemental-health>

Getting Mental Health Support Virtually

[En español](#)

It’s becoming more common for people to connect with mental health professionals virtually. Many online platforms make it easy for patients and providers to communicate through video calls, phone calls, text messaging, or email. This approach to care is often called telehealth or telemedicine.

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What mental health services are available virtually?

There are a variety of mental health services available virtually. Depending on your insurance and the type of provider you connect with, you may be able to receive:

- A mental health assessment, diagnosis, and treatment plan
- Individual, group, or family therapy
- A prescription for medication
- General care and support, including regular check-ins

Is telehealth effective?

Yes, virtual care can be effective for treating mental illnesses like anxiety, attention-deficit/hyperactivity disorder (ADHD), bipolar disorder, depression, and post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD).

What are the potential benefits of virtual mental health care?

- **Convenient:** Virtual visits do not require travel. This can make it easier to fit appointments into a busy schedule.
- **Flexible:** People can typically schedule telehealth appointments with less notice and at more flexible hours than in-person care.
- **Accessible:** Virtual appointments may reach people who cannot easily access in-person care, including those who cannot drive or live in remote areas.
- **Comfortable:** Connecting with a provider online may feel less intimidating than in-person care.

What are the potential drawbacks of virtual mental health care?

- **Access to technology:** Online appointments require an internet connection and a device like a smartphone or computer.
- **Issues with technology:** A poor internet connection or malfunctioning device can disrupt an online session. Navigating different devices or platforms can also be confusing.
- **Privacy concerns:** Virtual visits may feel less private if people nearby can see or overhear an appointment. Additionally, some people may feel uncomfortable using a camera at home, particularly if a provider can see their surroundings.

What should I consider when looking for a telehealth provider?

- **Insurance:** Check with your insurance provider or your health care provider's billing department to confirm your insurance covers telehealth appointments, as policies vary from state to state.
- **Security:** Find a provider who uses a secure platform that protects your privacy and verifies your identity.
- **Experience:** Look for a provider who has experience treating your symptoms. Ask them about their treatment methods and how long treatment typically takes.
- **Free introductory session:** Consider a provider who offers a free introductory session to decide whether they’re a good match.

Who can help me find a telehealth provider?

It may be challenging to find a telehealth provider. If you need help, talk to a primary care provider first. They may be able to refer you to a psychologist, psychiatrist, or clinical social worker who offers care virtually. Find [tips for talking with a health care provider](#) about your mental health.

You can [learn more about getting help](#) on the NIMH website. You can also learn about [finding support](#) and [locating in person or online mental health services](#) on the Substance Abuse and Mental Health Services Administration (SAMHSA) website.

If you or someone you know is struggling or having thoughts of suicide, call or text the [988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline](#) at **988** or chat at [988lifeline.org](#) . In life-threatening situations, call **911**.

More resources

- [MedlinePlus: Telehealth](#)
- [U.S. Department of Health and Human Services: Telehealth](#)

For more information

Learn more about [mental health disorders and topics](#). For information about various health topics, visit the [National Library of Medicine’s MedlinePlus](#) resource.

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